

ARM IN ARM Telangana CM Revanth Reddy (with folded hands) lending his support to Congress peers in Goa, Oct. 11

OPE FOR CONGRESS

'Save Goa Yatra', but the last mile is a big one

66. Karnataka's D.K. Shivakumar had dropped in at nearby Cortalim three days before. On Gandhi Jayanti, AICC general secretary Sachin Pilot walked with the cadre at North Goa's Sankhali, the constituency of CM Pramod Sawant.

Local media recorded high turnouts at a few legs, especially around Vasco-Zuarinagar, and the Congress claims a primordial pull to its plank: protecting Goa's "land, identity, environment, heritage and future". The yatra recalls the 2012 Jana Sampark Yatra of the late Manohar Parrikar, then leader of opposition. A watershed moment that ended the prior Congress era in Goa, it sent a scam-tainted Digambar Kamat regime hurtling towards an ignominious 9/40 tally. Add a purloined election five years later, and the circus-like spectacle of GOP leaders leaping like flocks of dolphins to the saffron ship over the next five, and the party has yet to recover. For the Congress, therefore, Rahul's Bharat Jodo Yatra is a happier analogy.

There's reason why the Congress is finding lift off the pitch now. Goa has been witnessing a rising tide of protests against the Sawant regime over issues like conversion of land, offshore casinos and linear projects. A series of historical factors are aligning here to produce anger. Villagers around Karapur-Sarvan agitated against a proposed mega-housing project by a powerful Mumbai-based real estate developer. This ties in with the widespread dismay among locals, which civil society members and activists have expressed, over the dilution of Goa's demography and culture. Its origins are complex: outbound Goan migration, a concomitant influx of non-local settlers looking for a 'second home', big realtors leaning into that market.

Takeaways

- **Congress's 'Save Goa Yatra' sees high footfalls**
- **Logs all 40 assembly seats in 27 days, till Oct. 18**
- **Taps into rising anger over land, culture, environment**

Yuri Alemao, leader of opposition and yatra convenor, calls it "a movement by the people of Goa for Goa. We are fighting land-grabbing, hill-cutting, corruption, fraud, unemployment and the sale of government jobs. Goa cannot be allowed to become the property of a handful of vested interests." The Congress has promised to scrap the controversial section 39(A) of the Goa Town and Country Planning (TCP) Act, which enables private-led commercial rezoning of land. AICC Goa in-charge Manikrao Thakre, the sutradhar, adds more key phrases: crime, transparency in law enforcement, and "the cultural and environmental heritage".

FOR A WHITER COALGATE

That last question isn't an easy one: mining is a notoriously grey area in the Goan psyche. Slogans like 'Goyant Kollso Naka' ('Goa Doesn't Want Coal') have been heard at protests against double-tracking of rail lines for transporting coal, and the Congress offers it fulsome backing, attacking the BJP for turning Goa into a "corporate coal corridor". Recent government moves to resume mining under a new auction regime, post a 2018 Supreme Court ban, faces fierce opposition from environmentalists. But for all its posturing now, a putative Congress regime will be forced to walk a fine line between them and a big slice of the local population that relies on mining for its livelihood—machinery operators, truck drivers, barge owners.

The subject doesn't tap into pleasant memories for the Congress. The political arena is likewise greyed by soot: an AAP-led 'Goa First' alliance threatens its votes. But academician Yugank Naik feels the yatra has helped the Congress re-enter the public consciousnes, and predicts a pure bipolar contest. BJP MLA Krishna Salkar mocks the "zero impact" yatra by a "three-MLA party" which wants to protect its flock. He's right in a way: the street cred will have to finally show on the odometer. ■